



▲ Wise woman

This early 19th-century Swedish print of an ancient, hunched “wise woman” consulted by a fashionable young woman underlines the increasing appeal that “cunning folk” held to members of high society.

SCIENCE OR SPELLS?

folk magic in Europe

With the spread of Enlightenment beliefs in reason and the growth of scientific method, 18th-century attitudes to witchcraft underwent a decisive shift. In essence, magic of whatever variety plainly did not exist in an Enlightened world, so it followed that neither could witches. This attitude was in stark contrast to the emotionally charged frenzy and suspicion that had led to waves of witch trials in the 16th and 17th centuries (see pp.178–181).

In Britain, for example, under the Witchcraft Act of 1735, anyone claiming supernatural powers, benign or malevolent, was self-evidently a fraud and prosecuted as such. Furthermore, the death

sentence was abolished for those found guilty, and was replaced by prison and/or a fine. Before the Act, the last person executed for witchcraft in Britain was a Scotswoman, Janet Horne, in 1727.

Healing folk

One consequence of this newly rational attitude was that in many parts of Europe, practitioners of folk medicine—“cunning folk”—found themselves under investigation for a variety of superstitious practices. But cunning folk were for the most part healers rather than practitioners of the dark arts, however much ancient lore they laid claim to.